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Four Feet of False Hope: NYC's Subway Safety Shame

It's 2025, and why are we still waiting for real subway safety in New York City? Too many people have been pushed onto the tracks. Many New Yorkers have spoken up, and countless articles have been written, but real action still has not been taken. Why is it taking so long?

Recently, the [MTA installed some '4-foot-tall gates'](#) at a few stations like 191st Street, Clark Street, and Morgan Avenue. These are set up along the platform edge to address what Governor Kathy Hochul called “that deep-rooted fear of someone pushing you onto the tracks.” But let's be real. They barely solve the problem, if at all. There is still plenty of open space where someone could easily be shoved onto the tracks. It is like putting up a “Wet Paint” sign and expecting people not to touch. These so-called barriers are not even tall enough to act as a real shield or keep out a determined toddler, let alone someone unhinged. It honestly feels more like a symbolic gesture, a way to quiet public concern, rather than a serious attempt to protect us. Sure, the 4-foot fences are a small step, but what comes next?

I take the subway to get to school, and every time, I feel anxious the moment I step into a station. I become hyper-aware, constantly scanning my surroundings. You will not catch me standing near the edge of the platform surrounded by a crowd. It might sound odd, but I always stay close to the ramp stairs, gripping the railing tightly. Even pressing my back against the wall does not feel safe enough. When there is no handrail, I sometimes just wait upstairs until I hear the train coming, then I rush down at the last second to board. It is not okay to commute every day, gripped by fear.

Getting home safely after school feels like a blessing and a small victory over “the subway shovers”. Since I live an hour and twenty minutes from campus, the train is the fastest and most logical option. Otherwise, you will not see me casually riding the subway since I never feel safe enough to let my guard down.

Full-height protective barriers are common in subway systems across Europe and Asia. Countries like Japan and China have done the right thing by installing these modern safety features, protecting commuters from accidents and deliberate harm. Meanwhile, NYC’s subway system remains outdated and long overdue for an upgrade. There are too many negative things I could mention about the NYC subway: the parade of rats, people getting fatally stabbed, and [the possibility of being set on fire](#), but today, I am focusing on just one terrifying issue: the constant fear of being pushed onto the tracks that affects me and many other New Yorkers.

We do not need these 4-foot-tall gates, we need secure platform barriers that separate passengers from the tracks, barriers as high as the train itself. Only that kind of design can offer true protection, not just the illusion of safety. Walking along the platform to reach a train, with rails on the left and rails on the right, is terrifying. I stayed tense the whole time, fearing someone might come out of nowhere and push me. I always walk fast, just trying to reach that one spot where I can find something, my best friend in that moment, a handrail, a pole, anything to grab onto and feel a little safer.

Installing full-height Platform Screen Doors (PSDs) can prevent more than just people from being pushed onto the tracks. Grace Cen and Jason Zhou, in their proposal published by the Harvard Undergraduate Urban Sustainability Lab, highlight how PSDs can reduce delays, prevent suicides and falls, help reduce litter buildup, improve air quality, and decrease noise pollution in subway stations ([Cen and Zhou](#)). So, a single decision like installing full-height PSDs can lead to multiple

benefits, enhancing the overall subway experience. There's no way those small, flimsy yellow or gray barriers recently installed could have the same impact... just saying.

Installing barriers on outdoor subway lines may be more complicated, but that's exactly why innovation is necessary. The Governor, the MTA, and other officials must stop using complexity as an excuse for inaction and waiting for tragedy to spark change. Each time a life is lost, condolences are sent, yet nothing changes.

Commuters, students, and all New Yorkers deserve to feel safe. We must keep pushing until meaningful and lasting protection is finally in place.

Textual analysis of my opinion essay

In my op-ed, I wanted to draw attention to the urgent and persistent problem of subway platform safety in New York City. Despite frequent incidents where people have been pushed onto the tracks, real, effective safety measures remain largely absent. My project aimed to highlight this issue as not only a public safety concern, but also as a failure of city infrastructure and leadership. I wanted to show that the current efforts, like the recently installed 4-foot metal barriers, are more performative than protective, and that we must demand stronger, more meaningful action.

My target publication is a widely read New York-based outlet like [amNY](#) with a readership that includes daily commuters, parents, and students. I imagined my audience as people who are aware of the dangers but may not realize how limited the current safety upgrades are. I sought to both reflect and amplify their frustration, while pushing them to demand real change.

To do this, I relied heavily on personal anecdotes to create emotional immediacy and relatability. By describing how I anxiously navigate subway platforms every day, I aimed to make readers feel the fear firsthand. I also used humor and blunt comparisons to systems in Japan and China to expose how far behind NYC is. Lastly, I cited a Harvard proposal by Grace Cen and Jason Zhou that explains how full-height Platform Screen Doors improve subway safety.

My structure gradually builds urgency and ends with a call to action: we cannot keep waiting for the next tragedy. Readers should leave not just informed but fired up to speak out.